Design Rationale — Feedback That Changes Behavior

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Overview

I designed a 12-minute, self-paced module that teaches new people managers to give specific, behavior-based feedback using the SBI model (Situation, Behavior, Impact, developed by the Center for Creative Leadership). The audience is new managers with no prior feedback training. The goal is for them to hold timely, specific feedback conversations instead of avoiding them or giving vague comments. I built the module in Lumi with H5P, made a one-page job aid in Canva, and hosted them on GitHub Pages. The company and characters are fictional. Many managers see giving feedback as confrontational. With this training managers can address concerns professionally and feel confident in their ability to work with the employee, not create an environment that produces friction.

Learning objectives

After the module, learners can:

1. Separate observable behavior from judgment in a feedback statement.
2. Write a feedback statement that names the situation, the behavior, and the impact.
3. Choose a suitable time, place, and format for a feedback conversation.
4. Respond to a defensive reaction while keeping the conversation on the behavior.

Key design decisions and why

1. **Show the difference before teaching it.** The module opens with two versions of the same feedback, one vague and one specific, and uses one running example (Maya and Chris) from the hook through the scenario. *Why:* Learners are more receptive to understanding real-life scenarios that apply to them and draw on their existing background knowledge. Beginning a lesson with jargon and lecture style materials is likely to bore or disengage them.

2. **Let every path continue, and show a stronger option.** In the scenario, a weaker choice still moves the learner to the next decision, and its coach note shows what a stronger choice would have been. I chose this over ending the scenario or sending learners back. *Why:* As human beings, we are not perfect. Not everyone is going to respond ideally in every scenario. Understanding how to get the conversation on track after a less than ideal response is more important than "getting it right" with each response.
3. **Give managers a simple test and a second step.** The "camera test" separates behavior from judgment, and a separate step reminds managers to stop talking and ask the employee for their view. *Why:* The more objective a manager can be by identifying behaviors over making judgements, the more receptive their employee is likely to be as they're not feeling like they need to defend themselves from judgment. Allowing the employee to engage in the conversation by asking for their point of view keeps things moving productively and collaboratively rather than a single-sided scolding.
4. **Tell learners what is coming before the check.** I added an intro slide before the questions, and every answer gives feedback and can be retried. *Why:* Learners respect an assessment and take it more seriously when they understand what it is designed to test. Feedback is essential to preventing learners from feeling like they don't know whether or not they're being successful. Constructive feedback reassures learners as they make mistakes and allows them to engage in reteaching and even reassessment if necessary.
5. **Choose tools I can keep, and design for access.** I built in H5P with Lumi so the module stays editable and hosted at no cost. I designed it to WCAG 2.1 AA principles and tested it with keyboard only, a phone-sized window, Mac, PC, and test subjects from different backgrounds. *Why:* Using a no cost platform allowed me time and space to make intentional decisions with instructional design. It allowed me to take the time to truly experience and acclimate to the tools as well as test the final product multiple times to ensure as seamless a user interface as possible. Creating a module that was WCAG 2.1 AA compliant was necessary to ensure accessibility for all learners just as I would have designed a classroom lesson to meet the needs of students with 504 plans, IEPs (Individualized Education Program) and SDIs (Specially Designed Instruction).

How I would evaluate it

The plan covers Kirkpatrick Levels 1 to 4. For Level 1, a short survey asks how useful and clear the module was. For Level 2, the five-question check measures whether learners can do what the objectives describe. For Level 3, a 30-day follow-up asks managers whether they held a feedback conversation with SBI and what happened. For Level 4, a team survey item such as "I receive useful feedback" would be compared before and after.

What I have done so far: I piloted Levels 1 and 2 with 4 testers and added navigational guidance for the module based on their comments. Levels 3 and 4 are a plan for a real rollout; I have not collected that data.

How I used AI

I used Claude to help draft the storyboard, scenario options, quiz questions, and checklists. I reviewed and edited that material, made the design decisions above, built the module in Lumi, created the job aid in Canva, and hosted it. I then tested the module with four testers. Before anything went into the module, I repeatedly checked accuracy, wording, accessibility, plausibility, and tone.